Veeraraghav. ‘In Tamil Nadu politics, Periyar has been a demigod for Dravidian politics. When you question Periyar’s legacy, you can open new political space.’ The basis of such a political challenge is the belief that a cultural transformation had taken place in Tamil Nadu over the years through soft saffron leaders who, while espousing the ideas of the Dravidian movement, had simultaneously financed temple repair funds and schools for temple priests. As the scholar Mahesh Rangarajan once pointed out, the late AIADMK leader Jayalalithaa supported the BJP’s right to kar seva in Ayodhya as far back as 1991.[116]

Appeals to a shared religiosity could, theoretically, break the ideological divide. ‘It needn’t be a Hindutva/Dravida faultline in Tamil Nadu. It can also be Rajni vs Dravida faultline,’ Veeraraghav pointed out. ‘Who said Periyar is not challengeable? BJP is keen to challenge Periyar. In a personality-focused state, they have found an ideological opposition and have started it. When was the last time Periyar was questioned in Tamil Nadu? Rajnikanth is opening the door for them.’[117] In the same vein, BJP Rajya Sabha MP and former Vice Chairman of Kerala NDA Rajeev Chandrashekhar told me in late 2019: ‘If I was a predicting man, Tamil Nadu in my opinion presents any political party an opportunity because the two Dravidian parties there have been governing with almost identical styling between the two of them. They both give lots of giveaways and have lived off the Karunanidhi and Jayalalitha mystique charisma for so many decades. So, their successes are dependent on all the same kind of leaders. There is, in my opinion, a vacuum there and an opportunity for BJP.’[118] The BJP has also been trying to take advantage of the vacuum created in the AIADMK by Jayalalithaa’s death in 2016. In September 2020, AIADMK leaders told reporters that BJP leaders had been mediating as their party and the rebel Sasikala faction held talks for a merger.[119] Even so, Tamil Nadu remains an uphill task for the BJP.

Many BJP leaders believe the party can make faster inroads in Telangana. The fact that it won four Lok Sabha seats[120] in the state in the 2019 national elections is seen by party strategists as a ‘golden opportunity’. ‘This is the first time. This is huge,’ one of them